

PRACTICE WORKBOOK

THE ULTIMATE ALTERNATE PICKING WORKOUT.

Every fingering combination, every way through the strings, in one unbroken pass.

The routine I have used for over thirty years of playing.

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HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Read This First.

This is my alternate picking routine and warm up. I have been playing for over thirty years, and I did not start doing this on day one, but I have done similar things throughout all those years. I feel it has benefitted my picking technique so much that it is worth talking about.

Part 1 is why I think it is worth doing this properly. Part 2 is the eleven fingerings. Part 3 is the three ways of going through the strings. Part 4 is how it all links together. Part 5 is positions and starting strokes. Part 6 is how long it takes.

At 60 BPM the whole routine takes seven minutes and eight seconds per position. Doing it once starting with a downstroke and once with an upstroke is around fifteen minutes, and that is what I usually do.

RUN IT IN THE APP

The app plays the routine for you. Every fingering and every string pattern in order, in time, with the tab on screen. It keeps your place, so your attention can go on how it sounds instead of on what comes next. It also logs which positions and which starting strokes you have actually done.

BEFORE YOU START

Start at 50 BPM. I very rarely go above 80, and mostly I am around 60.

Sometimes I use a metronome, sometimes I just count. That is up to you. What you want to do is keep an even tempo, and pick one you can actually play cleanly.

PART 1

Why It Is Worth Doing Properly.

Some people swear by learning licks instead, or pieces, or working on scale exercises you can actually use in music. Those are all valid approaches and I do them as well. But for quickly going through the most common movements that will appear in all those licks and scale exercises, a systematic approach is best, at least for me.

These Exercises Sound Like Crap

That might feel like a bad thing. I think it is a good thing.

Say you are trying to learn an Eric Johnson or a John Petrucci lick. You have heard it up to speed so many times that you sort of unconsciously push yourself to get to that speed, because you can hear how it is supposed to sound. And if you could play it up to speed as it should be, you would not need to practise it in the first place.

There is nothing to chase here. These exercises do not sound the same slowly either, and that is fine, because slow is the way you need to practise anyway. I do not need to play this fast. I do not have that sort of urge with it.

What I Am Actually Going For

I just want to be able to play it at a slow, even tempo, with technique and tone as close to perfect as I can get. That changes every day, and you always try to get a bit better in that department. It is not about speed. It is about evenness and not tensing up.

RAT · RELAXED, ACCURATE, TONE

Whatever I am practising on the guitar, I always have a pretty corny acronym in mind.

Relaxed. Do I feel tension anywhere? I stop, shake it out and try again. You should not feel tense when you are playing. Live, in the middle of a song, you have to push through. In practice you never do.

Accurate. That one sort of speaks for itself.

Tone. Whatever you find is the best tone for you.

PART 1 · CONTINUED

Tone, Sound And Tension.

Tone Is Part Of It

You see a lot of people really digging in when they practise technique, thinking that will somehow translate into perfectly executed awesome tone when they play for real. In my experience it does not work that way. You are programming your brain, and your brain controls what you do. Sit around practising super hard and you will probably play super hard, with pretty bad tone, if you can even play fast at all when you play that hard.

So whatever you feel is a good tone, strive for that, even when you are practising something as unmusical as this.

What I Play It On

I like doing this on my acoustic. You really have to be on the ball, keeping the dynamics even and all that stuff.

On the electric I go for my regular distorted tone with the volume rolled down to about a quarter, so I get a semi distorted sound. It is very dynamic, so I cannot really hide behind the distortion. And compared to a clean sound, if I get another string ringing I hear it much more easily.

That is my preference. Do whatever works for you.

You Should Not Get Tired

If you feel tense at all you need to stop and reset. Maybe start at a lower tempo, because if you are tensing up then something is up. You should not get tired doing this.

It is also really hard to do while watching Netflix. It is not a mindless exercise.

THE ONE RULE

Never faster than you can play it perfectly and completely relaxed.

PART 2

The Eleven Fingerings.

Divide the fretting fingers up by number, one two three four. Start with the two finger combinations, then the three finger ones, then the one with all four.

TWO FINGERS · 6**1-2****1-3****1-4****2-3****2-4****3-4****THREE FINGERS · 4****1-2-3****1-2-4****1-3-4****2-3-4****FOUR FINGERS · 1****1-2-3-4**

How To Remember The Order

The easiest way to remember these, and I never need a list beside me to see them all, is to think of the lowest number first. The lowest possible pair is 1-2. Then 1-3, then 1-4, then 2-3, 2-4, 3-4. Pretty easy.

The three finger groups work the same way: 1-2-3, 1-2-4, 1-3-4, 2-3-4. And finally 1-2-3-4.

Really you could do whatever you want here. Thinking about it like that makes it much easier for me to know where I am, so I do not skip any.

THE AWKWARD ONE

2-3-4 is pretty challenging for most people, so it is a good one to work on.

PART 3

Three Ways Through The Strings.

With all of these fingerings I have three ways of practising, and it is a cycle I go through: arpeggiated, adjacent strings, then string skips. You do all three for one fingering before moving on to the next one.

The tab shows the 1-2 fingering. I wrote everything out at the first fret because then it correlates with the actual fingerings, so you can read the fret numbers as finger numbers and move the shape all over the place.

1 · Arpeggiated

It just means I play the fingering repeatedly, but I change string every time. One on the low E, two on the A, one on the D, two on the G, one on the B, two on the top E. Sort of like an arpeggio, hence the name. Then back down.

1-2 · ARPEGGIATED10 NOTES

UP

□ ▼ □ ▼ □ ▼

e ————— 2 —

B ————— 1 —

G ————— 2 —

D ————— 1 —

A ————— 2 —

E — 1 —

AND BACK

□ ▼ □ ▼

e —————

B — 1 —

G — 2 —

D — 1 —

A — 2 —

E —

I do not double anything up when I turn around. I just go straight back.

PART 3 · CONTINUED

Adjacent Strings.

2 · Adjacent Strings

This just means you play it like you would play a scale, up and down. If you played a pentatonic scale in one position you would not hit the top note twice when you turned around, and it is the same here. You go straight back.

So it is one two, one two, one two all the way up, then one, then two one, two one, two one on the way back down.

1-2 · ADJACENT STRINGS

22 NOTES

UP

□ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □

e ————— 1 —

B ————— 1 — 2 —

G ————— 1 — 2 —

D ————— 1 — 2 —

A ————— 1 — 2 —

E — 1 — 2 —

AND BACK

▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽

e — 2 — 1 —

B ————— 2 — 1 —

G ————— 2 — 1 —

D ————— 2 — 1 —

A ————— 2 — 1 —

E ————— 2 —

Twenty two notes on the two finger version. With three fingers it is thirty four, and with all four it is forty six.

PART 3 · CONTINUED

String Skipping.

3 · String Skipping

You could do a lot of variations here. I stick to a regular one string skip, where I jump every other string.

Low E, then D, then back to the A, then G, then D, then B, then G, then the top E. Then I turn it around like I did before.

1-2 · STRING SKIPPING

30 NOTES

UP

□ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □

e ————— 1 —
 B ————— 1 - 2 —
 G ————— 1 - 2 ————— 1 - 2 —
 D ————— 1 - 2 ————— 1 - 2 —
 A ————— 1 - 2 —
 E — 1 - 2 —

AND BACK

▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽

e — 2 - 1 —
 B ————— 2 - 1 —
 G ————— 2 - 1 ————— 2 - 1 —
 D ————— 2 - 1 ————— 2 - 1 —
 A ————— 2 - 1 —
 E ————— 2 —

THE FOUR FINGER EXCEPTION

On the arpeggiated version with all four fingers I would run out of strings, and I want to have four strings to work with. So I start on the low E and go 1-2-3-4, then start again on the D string and go up to the top four. If you have an eight string that will work great. I have a regular six.

PART 4

One Unbroken Pass.

Each exercise stops one note short of the note it started on, because that note is where the next one begins. Play them in order and the whole thing is one long line.

What I try to do, and what I would recommend, is to go from one straight into the next without stopping. It takes more focus, and it actually takes less time.

The Picking Runs Straight Through

I am alternate picking throughout, and it does not restart at each exercise. Because the exercises are different lengths, the stroke you land on changes as you move through them.

You can get a clue from that. If you started the entire exercise on a downstroke, the last note before you shift to the next one tells you where you are.

Coming Out Of One Group Into The Next

You might wonder about the transitions. When I come back from the string skips on 1-4, the next combination is 2-3, so I do not go back to the index finger. All the other combinations start on either the second or the third finger, so once you know where you end it is not that hard to do.

The ideal is to go through the entire thing, the two finger combinations, the three finger combinations and the four finger one, without stopping. But if you feel tense at all you need to stop and reset.

PART 5

Positions And Both Strokes.

I demonstrate this at the fifth fret, but I wrote everything out on the first fret, because then it correlates with the actual fingerings. That is probably the best way to look at it, and then you just move the fingering all over the place.

Five Positions

If I feel like my chops are a bit frosty, I start on the first fret and do everything there. That covers the fretboard up to the fifth fret, so then I start on the fifth. Then the ninth, the thirteenth and the seventeenth. That gives me five positions.

I could technically go higher than the seventeenth, but I am rarely up there playing the lower strings and it is not comfortable, so I usually do not.

It is a different tension depending on where you are on the fretboard. Just because you can do something down here does not mean you automatically can play things up there. It feels different, and that is why you want to cover the whole neck.

Then Do It Again The Other Way

I do the entire thing starting with a downstroke, then do it again starting with an upstroke, because they feel different.

That is a pretty common thing. Everybody from Steve Morse to John Petrucci talks about practising exercises with a downstroke and with an upstroke, and I feel that is really important, so I highly suggest that you do that.

IN THE APP

The starting stroke is a setting, so the whole routine flips with one tap, and the progress page shows which positions you have finished in each direction.

PART 6

The Session.

Start at 50 BPM. I very rarely go above 80, and mostly I am around 60. At 60 the whole routine takes seven minutes and eight seconds per position.

WHAT	HOW LONG AT 60 BPM	WHEN
One pass	7 minutes	The least worth doing
Down and up	About 15 minutes	What I usually do
Two positions, both strokes	About 30 minutes	A good habit
All five positions, both strokes	About 70 minutes	When my chops feel frosty

At 50 BPM add about a fifth to all of those. At 80 take about a quarter off.

What I Actually Do

At least two rounds. The whole thing starting on a downstroke, then again starting on an upstroke.

Going up through all five positions and back down again is over an hour at that tempo. That is a long time, and by the end of it I am super wound up. I do not do it often. I try to do at least two positions, one somewhere down low and then one further up, because it is a different tension depending on where you are.

DO NOT RUSH IT

It is much better to do what I usually do, which is once with a downstroke and once with an upstroke, really slowly, trying to make everything as perfect as possible. That will help your technique more than rushing through all the positions.

After a few repetitions of these the gains sort of go down drastically, as would any exercise if you overdo it. Use common sense and it will be awesome.

I really feel this is a great way to start the day, and to make your first contact with the instrument a technical one. You can form really, really good habits by doing this correctly.

KEEP TRACK

Let The App Keep The Score.

It is a different tension depending on where you are on the fretboard, and starting on an upstroke feels different again. So what matters is which ones you have actually done, rather than which ones you think you have done.

That is the part the app is for. It logs every session: how long you played, at what tempo, in which position and which stroke you started on. The grid fills in as you go.

GROUND COVERED				PROGRESS	
	POS 1	POS 5	POS 9	POS 13	POS 17
DOWNSTROKE	✓	✓	✓	—	—
UPSTROKE	✓	—	✓	—	—

There is also a calendar with the time you put in on each day, and a running streak.

Inside Practice Lab it counts toward your overall practice log as well, so it is not a separate thing to keep.

THAT IS THE WHOLE THING

I hope you got something out of this, and that it will help you as much as it has helped me.

If you have any questions, feel free to email me and I will try to get back to you as soon as possible.